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Notes by the Wayside

(By John J. Inskip, County) While we struggle with the surplus of many agriculture products the poorly fed populations of the world look upon our abundant food supply with envy. They would gladly trade their problems due to shortage of food for ours incident to an over supply. Hitting an exact balance between supply and demand is a difficult and, as yet, unsolved problem. In no other nation does 12 percent of the population feed the other 88 percent. What would our position in the industrial world be if it now required 88 percent of our population to produce food as it does in many areas? Certainly if we are now producing the same amount of food products grown as late as 10 years ago we would have to import large amounts to feed our population on anything like the present high level of consumption. Present high food prices are due pretty much to ever increasing cost of distribution as most everyone is pretty well aware.

Our present favorable food supply situation, if it can be called such, is due to improvement in agricultural techniques and to power machinery, use of fertilizers, better insecticides,

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better control of plant and animal diseases, higher producing poultry flocks, and farm animals and to all around better 'know how.'

Corn planting time called this to mind. Standing at the seed counter the other day we noted a corn grower purchasing his season's needs of hybrid corn seed. Our thoughts went back to the Atlantic coast 50 years ago and to the corn belt state of Indiana 15 years or so later.

We well remember grandfather's old corn crib sitting on the hillside overlooking the bottom of the South Branch of the Potomac river in West Virginia. And the bottom lands of our farm—they were fertile and subject to corn belt conditions. The corner had a ventilating partition through the center, and rat invasions were numerous. There were before the days of warfarin rat poison.

A week before corn planting we pawed through a ton or so of ears selecting the best, or what we thought were the best. Tip and butt kernels were removed after which ears were run through the old hand low end roller. Present! We had our seed corn.

The Breeders Gazette has long since ceased publication. But in those days Joe Wing wrote of alfalfa and better seed corn in the gazette, our farmer's bible. We learned from the gazette to select our seed ears from the ripened stalks before husking time in October. Incidentally all of our corn was cut, bundled, and shocked by hand.

The stalk ears selected were stored separately and with special care to be used the following spring. So we made a step up the ladder of progress.

World War one found us finishing the sophomore year of Agriculture College. That would be Purdue University in Indiana where we had relatives. Farm labor was scarce so we were dismissed from classes in April and allowed to go home to put in the crops before enlisting in the Army.

We well remember the occasion. Our particular area had been subject to drought the previous season and we had no corn fit for seed. So we hitched old Tom the gelding to the sick wagon and drove to a relatives place 10 miles up the river where rain had been ample. There we selected our seed ears from the neighbor's crib.

In college we learned that one couldn't judge germinating vigor by looking at the corn kernel and that kernels from the same ear were likely to present a uniform germination pattern. In short, we had learned to use the rag doll tester. Anyhow, we marked off squares of strips of tough white cloth and gave each a number. Then we numbered each ear and from each removed six kernels. These were placed on the square corresponding to the ear number. After the squares were filled the cloth was rolled. The result was a rag doll tester. These were moistened and placed behind the kitchen stove for warmth. In a week or so the doll was unwrapped. The difference in the germinating ability of each ear was wondrous to see. Of course we kept only those ears whose kernels produced a vigorous sprout free

mes are present

Don't increase the acreage of potatoes this year with the expectation of repetition of the recent sharp rise in market. A year from now, M. D. Thomas, Agricultural Economist, Oregon State College has this to say about the potato outlook: "Skyrocketing potato prices may backfire in the form of distress markets next fall, if growers yield to the temptation to increase plantings."

A repetition of this year's freezes, and its psychological effects on the market, cannot be expected in the year ahead. A repetition of last year's acreage and yields would provide all the potatoes likely to move at reasonably satisfactory prices. A repetition of plant increases, such as have followed high potato prices of the past, would be too bad."

Wild mustard and radish plants have been pulled by hand from many of the promising crimson clover seed fields in Clackamas County, according to County Extension Agent Clive W. Cook. He believes that (Continued on Page 3)



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